

A PRIVATE CARTA PROPOSAL FOR JESSE GAUTHIER

Vietnam, three rhythms.

Hanoi's layered history, Hoi An's lantern-lit calm, and Saigon's full-volume food culture.

13 nights in Vietnam · Two travelers · 2028 concept priced against Feb 20 to Mar 6, 2027

THE IDEA

A first trip that feels specific, not overfilled.

I built this around the things you actually named: food, art, history, cultural depth, and a pace that leaves room to notice where you are.

The route moves north to south. Four nights in Hanoi establish the historical frame. Four nights in Hoi An slow the trip down. Five nights in Ho Chi Minh City let the food and contemporary energy land without turning every day into a checklist.

HANOI — ● HOI AN — ● SAIGON

WHAT THIS PROPOSAL ASSUMES

Travelers: Jesse and girlfriend

Starting point: IAD, selected over DCA because long-haul pricing and one-ticket options are materially stronger

Style: Value-conscious luxury, mostly strong 4-star hotels with opportunistic 5-star upgrades

Pace: Moderate, with one anchor activity per half day and protected free time

Pricing: Exact 2027 shopping snapshots used as a same-season planning proxy for a 2028 trip

THE ROUTE

Three cities. One clear arc.

Imperial and colonial layers in the north. Merchant history and craft in the center. Modern Vietnamese ambition in the south.

Why not add more?

Hue, Ha Long Bay, and the Mekong all merit time, but adding them to this length would trade depth for transit. I would rather give you a richer first trip and leave a reason to return.

01 Hanoi · 4 nights

02 Hoi An · 4 nights

03 Ho Chi Minh City · 5 nights

BIDV
CHAPTER ONE · FOUR NIGHTS

Hanoi

A city of courtyards, coffee, wartime memory, noodle smoke, and elegant contradictions.



HANOI PLAN

History first. Food always.

DAY 2 **Arrival and reset.** Private airport transfer, quiet check-in, then a short Hoan Kiem orientation walk only if energy allows.

DAY 3 **Old Quarter in context.** Small-group or private walking food tour, Hoan Kiem Lake, St. Joseph's Cathedral, and a café stop for egg coffee.

DAY 4 **Ideas and memory.** Temple of Literature, Hoa Lo Prison Relic, Vietnamese Women's Museum, then an unstructured evening.

DAY 5 **Art and living culture.** Vietnam National Fine Arts Museum, a focused craft or architecture walk, then a final Hanoi dinner.

FOOD SHORTLIST

Bun Cha Huong Lien · charcoal pork and noodles

Cha Ca Thang Long · turmeric fish at the table

Gia Truyen Bat Dan · classic pho, go early

Pizza 4P's Trang Tien · a useful modern break

Tam Vi · polished northern home cooking

I would book one destination dinner and keep the rest flexible enough to follow a local guide's best current call.

Three good versions of value.

Hanoi Fiesta Grand Hotel & Spa **\$74**

4-star · 4.9/5

Best pure value. Central, compact, and well reviewed. Choose this if most of the luxury should happen outside the room.

Displayed total: \$296 for 4 nights, before taxes and room-level terms.

Hanoi Tirant Hotel **\$102**

4-star · 4.6/5

My balanced pick. Old Quarter location, pool and spa, and enough polish without paying for a resort experience in a city stay.

Displayed total: \$408 for 4 nights, before taxes and room-level terms.

Lotte Hotel Hanoi **\$165**

5-star · 4.7/5

The opportunistic upgrade. Better facilities and skyline views, though less atmospheric than the Old Quarter.

Displayed total: \$660 for 4 nights, before taxes and room-level terms.

Also checked: Meliá Hanoi \$168/night, Pullman Hanoi \$98/night, Hilton Garden Inn Hanoi \$101/night. Rates shown by Google Hotels on July 19, 2026 for two adults.

CHAPTER TWO · FOUR NIGHTS

Hoi An

Merchant houses, regional cooking, riverside evenings, and enough quiet to make the middle of the trip feel like a pause.



HOI AN PLAN

Craft, ruins, then room to breathe.

DAY 6 **Fly south.** Morning flight Hanoi to Da Nang, private transfer to Hoi An, then an easy first loop through the Ancient Town.

DAY 7 **My Son, before the buses.** Early private guide to the Cham sanctuary, return for a long lunch, then free evening by the river.

DAY 8 **Market to table.** Morning market and hands-on cooking experience, followed by an open afternoon for a pool, tailor, spa, or café.

DAY 9 **Choose your pace.** Countryside cycling and Tra Que gardens, or a completely unscheduled day with dinner at a chef-led local restaurant.

FOOD SHORTLIST

Morning Glory Original · regional standards

Madam Khanh · bánh mì

Com Linh · central Vietnamese comfort food

Mango Mango · riverfront modern Vietnamese

Nữ Eatery · small plates near the Japanese Bridge

Hoi An is where I would leave the most white space. Its best moments are often the ones between bookings.

Resort calm without resort pricing.

Little Oasis Eco Friendly Hotel & Spa

\$76

5-star · 4.9/5

The deal hunter's pick. Full resort amenities at a rate that leaves room for experiences and better meals.

Displayed total: \$304 for 4 nights, before taxes and room-level terms.

La Siesta Hoi An Resort & Spa

\$111

5-star · 4.8/5

My recommendation. Strong service record, real resort breathing room, and a comfortable base between Old Town and a slower day.

Displayed total: \$444 for 4 nights, before taxes and room-level terms.

Hoi An Historic Hotel

\$106

4-star · 4.5/5

Best for walkability. A more central, garden-style stay when being near the Ancient Town matters more than a secluded resort mood.

Displayed total: \$424 for 4 nights, before taxes and room-level terms.

Also checked: Silkotel Hoi An \$45/night, Hoi An Silk Marina Resort & Spa \$101/night, Hoi An Odyssey Hotel \$56/night. Rates shown by Google Hotels on July 19, 2026 for two adults.

CHAPTER THREE · FIVE NIGHTS

Ho Chi Minh City

Fast, layered, generous, and best understood through the table.



SAIGON PLAN

The city's past, then its appetite.

- DAY 10** **Arrive and look up.** Fly Da Nang to Ho Chi Minh City, settle in, then a rooftop drink and unfussy dinner.
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- DAY 11** **The twentieth century.** Reunification Palace and War Remnants Museum with a guide who can add context rather than slogans.
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- DAY 12** **Chợ Lớn and street food.** Chinatown temples, markets, traditional medicine streets, then an evening tasting route by car or vintage Vespa.
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- DAY 13** **Art and design.** Fine Arts Museum, contemporary gallery stops, independent boutiques, and a chef-led dinner.
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- DAY 14** **One open day.** Optional early Cu Chi visit, a Mekong day, or stay in the city for coffee, spa, and last-minute shopping.
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- DAY 15** **Homeward.** Day room or late checkout if available, fly Saigon to Hanoi, then connect to the 11:50 PM international departure.

FOOD SHORTLIST

Ốc Đào · snails and seafood

Cơm Tấm Ba Ghiền · broken rice and grilled pork

Bếp Mẹ Ỉn · accessible southern classics

Anan Saigon · contemporary Vietnamese tasting

Hum · polished vegetarian Vietnamese

The Workshop · specialty coffee break

Five nights, three price points.

T-Ritz Saigon Hotel & Apartment

\$96

4-star · 4.9/5

Best value. Modern, highly reviewed, and easy to justify if the city itself is the main event.

Displayed total: \$480 for 5 nights, before taxes and room-level terms.

Mai House Saigon Hotel

\$144

5-star · 4.8/5

My recommendation. It feels like a proper finish to the trip without moving into trophy-hotel pricing.

Displayed total: \$720 for 5 nights, before taxes and room-level terms.

La Siesta Premium Saigon

\$181

5-star · 4.9/5

The splurge. Excellent guest scores, a strong central location, and a more boutique version of five-star service.

Displayed total: \$905 for 5 nights, before taxes and room-level terms.

Also checked: Winsuites Saigon \$104/night, The Odys Boutique Hotel \$59/night, Oakwood Hotel & Apartments Saigon \$63/night. Rates shown by Google Hotels on July 19, 2026 for two adults.

IAD wins this one.

ROUTING	SCHEDULE	STOPS	LIVE FARE
Outbound IAD to HAN Korean Air / Delta	Feb 20, 11:50 AM Arrive Feb 21, 9:45 PM 21h 55m	1 stop 1h 05m at ICN	\$1,306 per adult Round trip economy package
Return HAN to IAD Asiana / Korean Air	Mar 6, 11:50 PM Arrive Mar 7, 9:50 AM 22h 00m	1 stop 4h 30m at ICN	\$2,612 for two Taxes and required fees included

DCA would add a positioning segment and more ways for the trip to break. For a transpacific itinerary, the simpler IAD origin is worth protecting.

This is a shopping snapshot, not a held reservation. Baggage and advance seat selection can add cost.

PREMIUM ECONOMY REFERENCE

\$2,204 per adult was the lowest display, but the itinerary mixed cabins and the top return required a Tokyo NRT to HND airport transfer. I would not recommend it as shown.

PLANNING BUDGET · TWO ADULTS

A credible 2028 working range.

COMPONENT	BASIS	WORKING AMOUNT
International flights	Live 2027 IAD-HAN round trip snapshot	\$2,612
Hotels	Hanoi Tirant + La Siesta Hoi An + Mai House Saigon	\$1,572 displayed \$1,800 planning allowance with taxes/fees
Three domestic flights	HAN-DAD, DAD-SGN, SGN-HAN with checked bags	\$360 to \$520
Private transfers	Airport and intercity ground transfers	\$280 to \$420
Guides and experiences	Food tours, My Son, museums, cooking, art	\$650 to \$950
Meals and drinks	Mix of street food, casual restaurants, and 2 standout dinners	\$800 to \$1,150
Planning flex	2028 repricing, gratuities, minor changes	\$700 to \$950

COMFORTABLE WORKING TOTAL

\$7,200 to \$8,400

FOR TWO, BEFORE ADVISOR FEES AND INSURANCE

The biggest controllable lever is the long-haul cabin. A clean premium economy itinerary will likely push the total above this range once 2028 schedules open.

PRACTICAL NOTES

What I would lock first.

The route is sound. The next decision is not another city. It is the hotel mix and how much comfort you want to buy on the long-haul flight.

1. Choose the hotel level in each city. My balanced combination is Hanoi Tirant, La Siesta Hoi An, and Mai House Saigon.

2. Re-shop air when 2028 opens. I would prioritize one-stop IAD service through Seoul, Tokyo, or Taipei and reject any airport-change connection.

3. Hold the two scarce experiences. A strong Hanoi food guide and an early private My Son guide matter more than overbooking every dinner.

POWER AND CONNECTIVITY

Vietnam uses 220V power. Outlets commonly accept Type A, C, and sometimes F plugs. Most phones and laptops are dual voltage, but check hair tools before packing.

Bring one compact universal adapter per traveler and keep a charging brick in your carry-on. An eSIM plus hotel Wi-Fi is the simplest setup.

ENTRY AND HEALTH

Passport validity and Vietnam e-visa rules must be reconfirmed against official sources before ticketing. I would also review travel insurance, routine vaccines, and current health guidance at booking time.

MY RECOMMENDATION

Keep the route.
Spend selectively.

Use four-star value in Hanoi, take the resort upgrade in Hoi An, and finish with a real five-star stay in Saigon.

That puts the money where it changes the feeling of the trip, while preserving enough budget for the food, guides, and private transfers that make Vietnam easier to experience well.

Recommended hotel combination

Hanoi Tirant Hotel · La Siesta Hoi An Resort & Spa · Mai House Saigon Hotel

Recommended air strategy

One-stop from IAD, economy now as the planning floor, then re-shop a clean premium economy option when 2028 inventory opens.

PREPARED FOR JESSE GAUTHIER

Ready when you are.

This proposal is the planning frame, not a held booking. Once the hotel mix and cabin preference are confirmed, I can turn it into the trip.

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Sources: Google Flights and Google Hotels live shopping snapshots, hotel and attraction official pages, UNESCO destination references, and current traveler planning sources. All prices in USD and subject to change until booked.